

Czechmate by Krejčíková

No one predicted that two long shots would make the Wimbledon final — least of all themselves.

Jasmine Paolini, the Cinderella story of the French Open but dismissed here with 50-1 odds, had never won a main-draw match on Wimbledon grass. “Two Grand Slam finals in a row was crazy to believe, I think, no?” admitted the little Italian, who was overpowered by Świątek 6-2, 6-1 in the French Open final.

Barbora Krejčíková, dismissed at 100-1 odds despite being the 2021 Roland Garros champion, had an unimpressive 13-11 career record on grass and an abysmal 7-9 match record leading into Wimbledon, due to illness, a back injury, and rust. Yet the low-key Czech reignited her singles career — she had amassed seven doubles and three mixed doubles Slam titles — at the world’s most prestigious tennis tournament.

Known for her savvy tactics and versatility, the resourceful Krejčíková defused powerful Elena Rybakina 3-6, 6-3, 6-4 and exclaimed in surprise, “I’m in the finals. Wow!” After recovering from a mid-match collapse to defeat Paolini 6-2, 2-6, 6-4, the jubilant champion exulted, “Nobody believes that I got to the final. And I think nobody’s going to believe that I won Wimbledon. I still cannot believe it. It’s unbelievable.”

Sabalenka, seeded third at Wimbledon, withdrew when the rotator cuff injury she sustained in Berlin made serving difficult. Świątek suffered a disappointing 3-6, 6-1, 6-2 loss to No. 35 Yulia Putintseva, while Gauff was eliminated by the steadily improving 19th-seeded American, Emma Navarro, 6-4, 6-3.

Entering the Paris Olympics, Świątek, the firm favourite, had not lost on the Roland Garros clay since 2021, and Zheng had never beaten Świątek in six career encounters. Driven by “sheer determination,” the Chinese star achieved an impressive 6-2, 7-5 upset in the semifinals.

Zheng then seized the gold medal with an almost anti-climactic 6-2, 6-3 victory over 21st-ranked Donna Vekić of Croatia. “To be honest, I always dreamed of one day joining the likes of Yao, Liu, and Li, and being as successful and influential as they were as athletes,” an ecstatic Zheng, the first Chinese and Asian singles gold medallist, told China Daily. “I’ve been working so hard toward that goal, and [have] finally proved that I have what it takes to become the new leader of Chinese tennis. ... I feel so privileged and honoured.”

Maintaining control of her volatile emotions has always been key to Sabalenka controlling her high-velocity shots. That was of paramount importance at the US Open, where she had endured heartbreaking three-set losses over the previous three years to Gauff, Świątek, and Leylah Fernandez.

Everything went right for the Belarusian Basher at the US Open. She overwhelmed Zheng 6-1, 6-2 with a spectacular quarterfinal display of power tennis. Sabalenka exorcised her semifinal demons, beating Navarro 6-3, 7-6(2). In the on-court interview, Shriver asked Sabalenka if she was thinking about last year’s meltdown in the final.



Surprise package: Barbora Krejčíková, the 2021 Roland Garros champion, won Wimbledon against all odds. GETTY IMAGES

Sabalenka answered honestly, “I was thinking a lot.” And defiantly, “Not this time.”

Smacking 40 winners and playing the big points better, Sabalenka edged Jessica Pegula 7-5, 7-5 for her first US Open and third Grand Slam crown. During the trophy ceremony, the thoroughly impressed Pegula said, “She’s super powerful. She goes for her shots.”

A year after smashing two rackets in the locker room following her loss to Gauff, Sabalenka hugged and kissed her silver trophy and told *ESPN*, “I think I’m the happiest person in the world now.”

Gauff, who split with Brad Gilbert and hired Matt Daley after the US Open, salvaged her otherwise disappointing year at the WTA Finals. With a more consistent serve, she outplayed Pegula 6-3, 6-2, Świątek 6-3, 6-4, and Sabalenka 7-6 (4), 6-3 before outlasting Zheng 3-6, 6-4, 7-6 (2) in the thrilling final. Gauff became the first American to win the tournament since Serena in 2014.